June 2018, https://indianexpress.com/article/india/amit-shah-pm-narendra-modi-regards-northeast-as-ashta-lakshmi/.

28. Sheldon Pollock, *The Language of Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture, and Power in Premodern India* (New Delhi: Permanent Black, 2007 edition, originally published by University of California Press, Berkeley), p. 14.

29. Ibid.

30. Arkotong Longkumer, 'Playing the waiting game: The BJP, Hindutva, and the Northeast', in Angana P. Chatterjee, Thomas Blom Hansen, Christophe Jaffrelot (eds), *Majoritarian State: How Hindu Nationalism Is Changing India* (New Delhi: HarperCollins, 2019), p. 284. Also see Arkotong Longkumer, 'The power of persuasion: Hindutva, Christianity, and the Discourse of Religion and Culture in Northeast India', *Religions*, Vol. 47, No. 2, 2017, pp. 203–227.

31. Phone interview with a senior newspaper editor in Guwahati, speaking on condition of anonymity.

32. Historians debate the exact geographic contours and dates of these kingdoms but there is general agreement that ancient Pragjyotish at various points extended over an area bigger than modern Assam, extending to the eastern boundary of Assam. It is 'generally believed' that Pragiyotisha-Kamarupa 'included a vast tract of land: viz., the North Bengal, north and east Bangladesh, modern Assam and its neighbouring hilly regions with the boundary in the north reaching the foot hills of the border of Tibet …' Nirode Boruah, 'The Kingdom of the Doiyangdhansiri Valley of Assam', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress,* 2000–2001, Vol. 61, Part One: Millennium (2000–2001), p. 174; K.N. Dutt, 'Problems in the history of Assam', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 1960, Vol. 23, Part - II (1960), pp. 164–169. Also see Nirode Boruah, 'The Kingdom of the Kapili Valley of Assam', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 2001, Vol. 62 (2001), pp. 135–143; Suchandra Ghosh, 'Kamarupa and Early Bengal: Understanding their political relationship', *Proceedings of the Indian History Congress*, 2010–2011, Vol. 71 (2010–2011), pp. 110–118; Nirode Boruah, 'Sanskritization and detribalization in